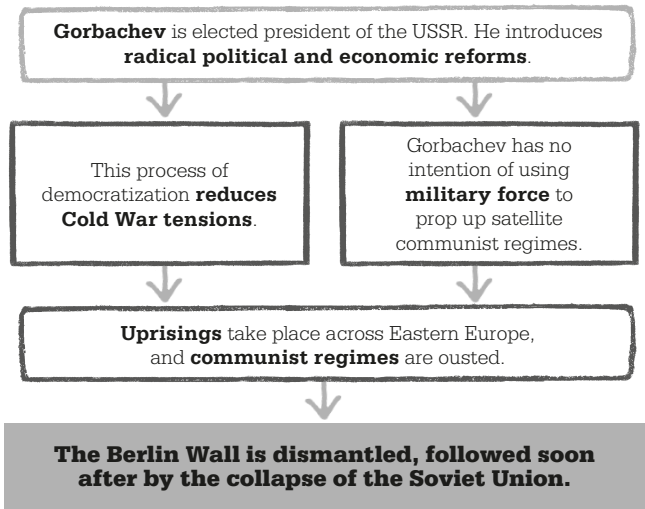




economic “restructuring”). Critically, he lifted the ban on Eastern Bloc countries reforming their political systems.

Collapse of communism

With the threat of Soviet military intervention removed, citizens in all Eastern Bloc countries protested to end communist rule. In June 1989, Poland’s Solidarity, originally a banned trade union, was elected to lead a coalition government. As the push for reform gathered pace, the East German government declared that its citizens would be able to visit West Berlin through any border crossing, including the Berlin Wall.

The fall of the Berlin Wall was a momentous event. It marked an era that saw the end of the Cold War and the dissolution of the Soviet Union. It allowed millions to travel more freely, and previously stifled economies across Eastern Europe and the Former Soviet Union opened up to the world. Many former communist countries were welcomed into NATO and joined the European Union.

The world changed course in 1989. Communism was dead in the East, and a reunified Germany was about to take its place at the heart of Europe. ■

The breakup of the Soviet Union

In 1985, Mikhail Gorbachev became leader of a stagnating Soviet Union. He laid out radical reforms—*glasnost* and *perestroika*—and in July 1989 he announced that countries within the Warsaw Pact could hold openly contested elections. Poles, Czechs,

Hungarians, and others opted for democratic governments, destabilizing the Soviet Union itself.

In July 1991, the anti-communist Boris Yeltsin was elected president of Russia. A month later, with Gorbachev weakened by an attempted coup by hard-line communists, Yeltsin took advantage. He banned the Communist

Party in Russia and met secretly with the leaders of Ukraine and Belarus, who agreed to secede from the Soviet Union. On Christmas Day 1991, Gorbachev resigned, leaving Yeltsin as president of the new Russian state. The former empire split into 15 new independent states, and the USSR was no more.